

AI MARKETPLACE

MVP Scope

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Status: Draft — Authoritative (supersedes v0.2's message-gated contact flow; adds Trust & Reviews layer, growth levers, outcome tracking, provider value-adds, arrival-verification OTP, and portfolio field)

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Audience: Engineering Team, Product Team, AI Assistants

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Purpose

This document defines what is and is not built in v1. It is authoritative for sprint story scoping. No implementation story may introduce functionality outside this defined scope without a formal scope change recorded in [09_DECISIONS.md](#).

Concept v0.1 targeted full in-app booking and payment as the MVP. That was pulled back in v0.2 to a request-for-quotation (RFQ) flow, then to a single-message-and-reply contact flow. This v0.3.0 update makes a further, deliberate strategic change:

Priority is now userbase growth first, monetization later. Contact details (phone number) are shown directly once a customer views a matched provider — there is no message-first gate, no "reply unlocks contact" step, and no lead-based revenue collection at launch. This is a conscious trade-off, not an oversight: it trades away pay-per-lead as a near-term revenue lever (contact is no longer something the platform controls or can meter) in exchange for lower friction and faster adoption. Monetization, once pursued, will need to rely on levers that don't depend on gating contact — e.g. featured/priority placement, verified-badge subscriptions — rather than pay-per-lead. This is recorded as a decision, not left implicit; see [09_DECISIONS.md](#).

The AI-based conversational intake **is retained** — it still runs before results are shown. What's removed is only the post-match contact gating, not the matching intelligence.

The end state is still full in-app booking, payment, and staged disclosure (see Section 4, Build Sequence) — exclusions remain deferrals, not permanent decisions.

1. Include in MVP

- Customer registration — Google, Apple, or mobile number verified by OTP. **No guest path.**
- AI-based service request conversation (understand → ask → match → explain), LLM-API + RAG-grounded against the provider database. **Retained** — the AI intake step still runs before results are shown; only post-match contact gating is removed (see below).
- Location and service-area matching.
- Ranked list of matched providers (Business or Freelancer) — name, services, service area, price range shown.
- **Contact details (phone number) are shown directly once the customer views a matched provider.** No message-first gate, no "reply unlocks contact" step, no instant-booking path.
- Provider availability — working hours, emergency/urgent availability.
- Provider onboarding, two paths:
 - **Business** — initially seeded from publicly available Google listings (see Section 7 for the associated legal/ToS check needed before bulk import) as unclaimed/unverified entries, plus direct self-registration.
 - **Individual/Freelancer** — self-registration only, gated on submitting a freelance license or equivalent service-provider credential for verification before the listing goes live.
- Provider dashboard — basic profile management, availability, status updates (Contacted / Booked / Completed / Cancelled).

- Admin dashboard — manual verification (freelancer license, claimed Google listings), request/profile review.
- **Verified reviews and ratings, anchored to platform-driven contact.** A customer may only review a provider they viewed contact details for through the app (tied to that AI-matched Request record) — one review per request. See Section 2 for detail.
- WhatsApp / SMS / email notifications for status updates.
- Mandatory license/ID verification for freelancers before their listing goes live. Google-sourced business listings are marked **unclaimed** until the business confirms ownership and completes basic verification.
- **Bilingual UI — English and Arabic.** Confirmed as already planned, documented here so it isn't lost or treated as scope creep if raised again later. Build in from the start rather than retrofitting after launch.
- **Shareable provider profiles** — a deep link a customer can send via WhatsApp/SMS to share a specific provider they found. Low build cost, direct growth lever given WhatsApp's role as the default communication channel in this market.
- **Admin-side search analytics** — surface which AI-intake searches return few or no matches, broken down by category/area. Feeds directly into the category-taxonomy and supply-recruitment priority decision already flagged as a blocking dependency.
- **Customer outcome tag.** A lightweight, optional prompt in "My Requests" — "Did you end up hiring [Business]?" (Yes / No / Didn't respond). This is the platform's only signal on whether a match ever converts into a real job, and strengthens the review anchor.
- **Claim-your-listing flow**, needed for the Google-seeded business supply to actually work: a business searches for its own name, requests to claim, verifies via OTP to a phone number matching public business records, or falls back to admin manual approval.
- **Basic visibility analytics for providers** — "your profile appeared in X searches, Y people viewed your contact this [period]." Reuses the same event log already built for admin search analytics — near-zero extra build cost.
- **Provider profile framed and built as a free mini digital storefront** — not just a lead source. A clean, shareable profile (services, photos, reviews, visibility stats) is valuable on its own, complete enough to stand alone if shared outside the app.
- **Optional arrival-verification OTP.** Once contact is made, the platform generates a single OTP tied to that Request, sent to the customer ("give this code to [Provider] when they arrive"). The provider enters it in their app on-site to confirm physical arrival. **Optional, provider's choice per job — not mandatory.** Confirms presence only, not job completion or quality. Earns a **"Verified Visit"** tag.
- **Portfolio field on the provider profile** — before/after photos, certifications, years active. Cheap extension of the digital-storefront profile.

2. Trust & Reviews Layer

Goal: let a small, genuinely good provider compete on merit, not marketing spend — verified reviews and merit-based ranking are the mechanism, not a paid boost.

Verification anchor (MVP scope): a customer can only leave a review for a provider whose contact details they viewed through the app's own AI-matched flow — the review is tied to that specific Request record, one

review per request. This does not prove a job was completed (there's no payment/booking record to confirm that, per Section 6), but it does prevent the most common abuse pattern: reviews from people who never actually found the provider through the platform (competitors, plants, unrelated parties).

Stronger tier — "Verified Visit." When a provider optionally uses the arrival OTP (Section 1), the confirmed Request is tagged as a Verified Visit — a step up from plain contact-view, since it confirms the provider physically arrived. Reviews on Verified Visit requests should be visibly distinguished (e.g. a badge) from plain anchor-only reviews — but note this still confirms *presence*, not job quality or completion; don't over-represent it as a completion guarantee in UI copy.

Explicitly deferred to a later phase (not this MVP round)

- Automated post-contact follow-up nudge ("Did you use this business? Rate your experience") — would improve capture rate but adds a scheduled-notification dependency not needed for launch.
- Repeat-customer/"Returning Customer" badge weighting.
- Completion OTP (a second code exchanged at job-end, for a full arrival + completion signal) — considered and deliberately deferred; MVP ships arrival-only.
- These are natural Stage-2 additions once the anchor-only version is live and review volume is real.

Merit-based ranking, not spend-based. Search/match ranking must weight rating average, review count, recency of activity, and **Verified Visit rate** — not account age, listing type, or anything resembling paid placement. This is what actually delivers "small business gets discovered."

Abuse guardrail: flag reviews left unusually soon after account creation, or unusual review-timing patterns per provider, for manual admin look — a lightweight rule, not a full fraud-detection system, appropriate for MVP scale.

3. Explicitly Excluded from v1

- Any payment processing — deferred indefinitely until a monetization phase is deliberately kicked off. No payment infrastructure of any kind at launch.
- Any monetization mechanism at launch — no pay-per-lead, no subscription, no featured-placement billing. Growth first, monetize later, by deliberate strategy.
- Staged/gated contact disclosure. Considered and explicitly dropped for launch — contact is shown directly on viewing a matched provider.
- Persistent in-app chat/messaging system (real-time delivery, multi-turn threads, read receipts).
- Instant/predefined fixed-price booking.
- Full scheduling optimization.
- Loyalty programs, advanced subscriptions, automated dispute management.
- Dozens of service categories — start narrow, expand once matching is proven.

None of these are a "never." Each is a real later-phase feature, deliberately deferred so v1 ships fast.

4. Build Sequence (Reference)

Stage	What Ships	Why This Order
1	Directory + location/category search, provider & customer profiles	Proves the core discovery loop with zero payment/verification dependency
2	AI-based intake conversation (LLM-API + RAG-grounded) + direct contact display + provider dashboard	Differentiated core; ships with manual (Wizard-of-Oz) fallback rather than waiting for a fully automated matcher
3	Mandatory freelancer ID verification (OCR-based pipeline) + admin dashboard	Required before trust-sensitive transactions go live; gates public launch
4	WhatsApp/SMS/email notifications + reviews/ratings	Completes the transactional loop and closes the feedback cycle
5 (post-v1)	Pay-per-lead billing / subscription tier	Revenue layer, added once there is real lead volume to monetize
6 (later)	Anti-circumvention hardening (masking, message-content filtering, leakage analytics)	Deferred until leakage is provably costing real revenue
7 (long-term)	In-app payment, escrow, payout, full booking automation	Highest complexity — built once Stages 1–4 have proven real usage

Timeline — revised for native mobile. The prior 6–10 week estimate assumed a web app with instant deploys and no store review cycle. Native adds cross-platform build overhead (recommend Flutter or React Native — single codebase, not separate iOS/Android native builds), app store review cycles (Apple: ~1–7 days per submission, including bug-fix releases), and TestFlight/Play internal testing rounds. **Revised estimate: 12–16 weeks for a stable v1**, treating 12 as the floor and 16 as realistic with buffer for first-submission review friction and ID-verification integration.

5. Anti-Circumvention — Deferred, Not Day-One

With contact shown directly and no monetization at launch, there is nothing to "circumvent" yet — off-platform leakage only matters once the platform is charging for something contact-adjacent (a lead fee, a placement fee, a subscription). Anti-circumvention mechanics (staged disclosure, ToS restriction on solicitation, lead-quality guarantees) are **not built at launch** and are revisited only once monetization is deliberately reintroduced. Do not build masked communication, contact-info gating, or leakage monitoring in v1 — there is no revenue mechanism yet for them to protect.

6. Revenue Model — MVP Approach

None, deliberately, at launch. Strategy is userbase growth first: free for both customers and providers, no lead fees, no subscriptions, no placement fees. Monetization is picked up as a distinct later phase once real usage/liquidity exists, and will need to rely on levers that don't require gating contact (e.g. featured/priority placement, verified-badge subscription), since contact is no longer something the platform meters. Full future revenue model detail lives in `00_PROJECT_CONTEXT.md` Section 6, updated to reflect this shift.

7. Open Risks — Flag for 13_OPEN_DECISIONS.md

- **Google-sourced business listings — legal/ToS check needed before bulk import.** Google's Places API terms restrict how place data can be cached/reused, including limits on building a competing directory from it. Confirm current terms (or get a quick legal read) before importing business listings in bulk. Until resolved, imported listings should be flagged internally as **unclaimed** and not treated as equivalent to verified, self-registered providers.
- **Unclaimed listings and unsolicited contact.** Businesses pulled in from Google haven't opted in and may receive calls/messages they didn't expect. Decide whether unclaimed listings are hidden from search until claimed, or shown with a clear "unclaimed — unverified" label.
- **App Store policy on off-platform payment.** Apple App Store review scrutinizes marketplace apps that connect users for services paid off-platform, which is this product's model. Needs a resolution strategy before development begins.
- **Monetization path narrows — mitigation.** Dropping contact-gating at launch removes pay-per-lead as a straightforward later option. Mitigation already built into this MVP round: provider-facing visibility analytics create a natural, non-disruptive upsell path ("boost your visibility") that doesn't require re-gating anything users already expect to be free. The digital-storefront framing also gives providers a reason to stay on the platform independent of any lead volume.

8. Scope Guardrails for AI-Assisted Implementation

AI assistants implementing sprint stories must not implement, even incidentally:

- Payment or escrow logic of any kind.
- Any lead-fee, subscription, or placement-fee billing logic.
- Contact-gating/disclosure-staging logic of any kind (explicitly removed for launch).
- Persistent/multi-turn in-app chat infrastructure (websockets, message threads, read receipts, typing indicators).
- Instant or predefined fixed-price booking flows.
- Masked-communication/telephony proxy integration.
- Message content scanning/filtering.
- Loyalty, dispute-automation logic.
- Making arrival-verification OTP mandatory, or building a second completion-OTP step — both explicitly deferred (Section 2).

...unless a story explicitly scopes it and 13_OPEN_DECISIONS.md / 09_DECISIONS.md have been updated accordingly.

Related Documents

- 00_PROJECT_CONTEXT.md
- 03_DOMAIN_MODEL.md

- 13_OPEN_DECISIONS.md

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